



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Brilla College Prep Middle

School Website: <https://brillaschools.org/our-schools/brilla-college-prep-middle/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**Executive Summary**

Brilla College Prep Middle School (Bronx, NY 10454) demonstrates a discernible classical orientation centered on virtue, character formation, and a rigorous academic culture, but it does not consistently articulate or implement the full spectrum of classical education's core practices (e.g., Great Books, grammars of language, Socratic pedagogy, liturgical or religious scaffolding, and a living, mentor-driven faculty culture) in publicly surfaced materials. The public materials emphasize virtue-centered education, character formation, and college-oriented outcomes, with explicit notes about openness and access (e.g., free enrollment, no entrance exams). However, there is limited evidence of explicit liberal arts curriculum elements (grammar–logic–rhetoric), Great Books study, or the full spectrum of classical pedagogy (Socratic seminars, memory work, chanting, or a formal “living curriculum”). On balance, the school shows meaningful classical cues but does not consistently meet the full rubric across all six categories. Overall, Brilla College Prep Middle School is best characterized as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with clear opportunities to move toward CLASSICAL in multiple areas.

Key public signals observed: - Emphasis on virtue and character in service of collegiate and life outcomes (e.g., “academically rigorous and virtue-centered education,” “developing the minds and hearts,” “character necessary to succeed in college and beyond”). - Public commitment to accessibility and equity (free enrollment, no entrance exams) and a statement of joyful, relationship-based culture. - Presence of a Humanities faculty role and K-8 orientation, but no explicit Great Books, grammar-logic-rhetoric sequence, or explicit Socratic pedagogy in the surfaced materials. - The school's branding as part of a network of eight Brilla schools emphasizes high performance and college-going expectations, with a continued focus on virtue-centered learning.

The following category-by-category analysis uses the Six Essential Elements' Positive/Negative Keyword indicators as the scoring framework, triangulated with the Brilla materials cited above and the classical lexicon.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot**Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**

Evidence - Public materials emphasize virtue-centered education and character formation as foundational aims (e.g., “academically rigorous and virtue-centered education,” “developing the minds and hearts of our students...character”). - The site does not present explicit references to theology, liturgy, or liturgical practice. There is no stated grounding in theology or liturgical worship in the surfaced content.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: virtue, character (Element 1 positives in the Classical Lexicon). The lexicon lists virtue and the virtuous life as core positive signals; “theology,” “liturgy,” and related liturgical practices are not surfaced. - Negative indicators: no explicit messaging around relativism, secular humanism, or morally neutral schooling; however, the absence of theology or liturgy weakens a full Classically religious/metaphysical grounding. The absence is informational rather than explicit negative signal.

Why this rating - The school clearly foregrounds virtue and character formation, aligning with the Positive keywords for Element 1 (virtue, moral realism). The lack of explicit theological grounding, liturgical practice,

or metaphysical theology reduces it from CLASSICAL to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. The Brilla materials show moral formation as central, but do not present a comprehensive religious/metaphysical program as defined by the full Classical rubric.

What would move the needle - Articulate a grounded metaphysical or theological framework (even in a non-denominational form) and integrate liturgical or communal practices (e.g., a morning routine with reverence or sung/musical elements aligned with a shared calendar). This would elevate Element 1 toward CLASSICAL. See the lexicon's emphasis on theology, liturgy, and sacred practices as key signals for a higher rating.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school foregrounds virtue-centered formation and character development as central aims, with explicit emphasis on equipping students to succeed in college and beyond (a life of learning and virtue leading to long-term outcomes). The public materials emphasize formation and character as central aims rather than a narrow "workforce prep" stance.. - The Brilla network emphasizes high performance and college-going trajectories, in line with a classical vision of education as formation toward human flourishing, even as it foregrounds college outcomes..

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators: formation, virtue, human flourishing, wisdom (from the lexicon's categories). The Brilla materials emphasize formation of virtue and character; "pursuit of the true, good, and beautiful" is not explicitly stated, but the virtue-centered framing aligns with core positives in Element 2. - Negative indicators: explicit emphasis on "college and beyond" and workforce trajectories could tilt toward a more utilitarian, post-secondary prep framing; however, the surfaced materials still frame college as a pathway rather than a sole end.

Why this rating - The school's stated aim emphasizes formation, virtue, and wisdom in service of meaningful human flourishing, with college and life outcomes as a horizon. This aligns with Element 2's formation-focused trajectory, though the heavy college/outcome framing suggests it is not fully aligned with the more radical, leisure-and-virtue-centered telos of classic paideia. The result is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle - More explicit articulation of the true telos (the pursuit of the true, good, and beautiful) and a claim to a liberal-arts paideia as the central formation goal (not primarily college-readiness). Explicitly naming "scholé" and a contemplative, rest-focused cadence would push the rating toward CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe an academically rigorous, virtue-centered program and a K–8 structure, with emphasis on college readiness and character development. There is no surfaced evidence of a liberal-arts curriculum in the Trivium sense (grammar, logic, rhetoric), no explicit mention of Great Books, no heavy emphasis on Latin/Greek or primary sources, and no reference to historical breadth through Western civilization in the curricular language provided.. - The content highlights "humanities" in the sense of a subject area and teacher specialization but does not reveal the canonical classical elements (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; memory work; classical languages). This contrasts with the classical lexicon's prescribed curricular signals (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; history as a liberal-arts core).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators: mentions of "great books," "liberal arts" and other canonical curricular signals are not surfaced in the Brilla materials. The lexicon identifies liberal-arts-forward cues as positives; Brilla's surfaced content does not demonstrate these cues. Therefore, positive keyword presence is minimal to none in the surfaced public materials. - Negative indicators: the absence of standard classical curriculum signals (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; Latin/Greek; primary sources) is a negative signal for Element 3 from a classical perspective.

Why this rating - The absence of classical curriculum signals in the surfaced Brilla materials leads to a NOT CLASSICAL classification for Element 3. The Brilla materials emphasize virtue-centered, college-oriented outcomes rather than a liberal-arts curriculum with the core classical scaffolds.

What would move the needle - Explicitly adopt a Trivium-based curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric) with a history canon built around Great Books or primary sources, and implement a Western civilizational survey integrated across grades. Add Latin/Greek or classical-language components and a systematic history sequence that aligns with “history throughout the curriculum” as a canonical element. These steps would move Element 3 toward CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The surfaced Brilla materials show a Humanities teacher and general K–8 structure, with no explicit mention of Socratic seminars, memory work, chanting, recitation, or other classical pedagogy signals. The content also does not reveal a dedicated Scholé rhythm (restful learning days, contemplative cycles) or an explicit upper-school rhetoric festival or debates program.. - The site highlights a joyful, virtue-centered culture and relationship-building but does not demonstrate the explicit, recurring use of contemplative or Socratic pedagogy that characterizes classical pedagogy as described in the lexicon..

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators: within the classical pedagogy lexicon, signals include Socratic seminars, narration/recitation, memory work, chanting, and memory-driven pedagogy. These are not visibly present in the surfaced Brilla materials. The only proximate signal is the inclusion of a humanities-focused teacher role, which is insufficient for a strong positive signal. - Negative indicators: absence of explicit classical pedagogy signals (Socratic dialogue, Paideia seminars, memory work, recitation, liturgical or contemplative cycles) is a negative signal for Element 4.

Why this rating - Without explicit, regular use of Socratic/Paideia-based pedagogy, chanting, or memory work, Element 4 remains NOT CLASSICAL. The presence of a humanities focus is not enough to meet the canonical pedagogy signals in the Classical Lexicon.

What would move the needle - Implement a structured classical pedagogy across grades: regular Socratic seminars, memory work, narration/recitation cycles, and a deliberate shift to a rest-focused Scholé rhythm with contemplative learning days. Develop students’ rhetoric through speeches and debates in upper grades. These changes would move Element 4 toward CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public content displays teacher roles (e.g., “8th Grade Humanities Teacher” Ben Ashley) and a general sense of staff involvement, but it does not present a publicly stated “living curriculum” or a portrait of ideal teacher/student archetypes as the core of the school’s instructional model. The faculty is visible, but not elaborated as a “living curriculum” or as “model teachers and mentors” in the classical sense..

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators: the lexicon’s Classically oriented signals include “tutors, masters, mentors, guides, sages, exemplars” and “living curriculum” and “portrait of a teacher.” These signals are not explicitly surfaced in Brilla’s public materials. The presence of a named humanities teacher is not, by itself, a positive signal for the classical living-curriculum standard. - Negative indicators: absence of a stated “portrait of a teacher” or “faculty as living curriculum” weakens Element 5’s classical alignment.

Why this rating - While Brilla demonstrates a commitment to faculty, the surfaced materials do not reveal the classical-model presentation of faculty as living, virtuous exemplars who form the curriculum. Thus, Element 5 is NOT CLASSICAL given the lack of explicit living-curriculum or teacher-portrait signals.

What would move the needle - Publish and operationalize a formal “Faculty as Living Curriculum” framework (clear portraits of teacher virtues and teaching excellence; ongoing faculty seminars on classical pedagogy; mentorship culture among teachers; and explicit expectations for teacher-student moral formation). This would move Element 5 toward CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Brilla site has a Families section with contact points and an emphasis on accessibility (free enrollment, no entrance exams). There is limited public evidence of structured parent formation, formal parent-book clubs, or open-campus partnerships with a defined classical-education formation agenda. The materials emphasize family involvement in general terms (e.g., “Families” and “contact operations”), but do not present a robust, explicit model of parents as co-teachers or formal household-liturgical alignment.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators: the lexical signals for Element 6 include “partnership with parents, co-teachers, parental primacy,” “parent formation,” “open campus,” “parent covenant.” These signals are not substantively surfaced in the Brilla pages (the content shows Families contact points but not a robust parent-formation program). - Negative indicators: absence of explicit parent-formation activities, regular parent seminars, or a visible program of family engagement and liturgical/homiletic alignment.

Why this rating - The surfaced Brilla materials show basic engagement with families (via a Families contact channel and openness to visits) but do not demonstrate the robust parental formation or co-teacher partnerships that characterize CLASSICAL Parent & Community practice. Therefore Element 6 is NOT CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle - Create and publicly document a comprehensive Parent & Community program: parent book studies, classical book clubs, regular parent education on classical education philosophy, and open-campus opportunities with a formal “parents as co-teachers” framework. Regular visits, gatherings, and liturgical-calendar community events would further align this category with CLASSICAL.

Aggregate Assessment

- Element 1: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 2: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 3: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: NOT CLASSICAL

Overall, Brilla College Prep Middle School is BEST CLASSIFIED AS SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with meaningful signals of virtue-centered formation and college-oriented rigor but lacking the core canonical elements (Great Books, Trivium-based curriculum, explicit Socratic pedagogy, living-curriculum faculty, and robust parent/community classical-education integration) that define a fully CLASSICAL model. The strongest improvements would come from explicitly adopting and communicating a liberal-arts curriculum and pedagogy rooted in grammar–logic–rhetoric; implementing Socratic and memory-based teaching; forming a living-faculty model; and deepening parental and communal partnership in the classical sense.

What would move the needle (summary) - Adopt and publicly publish a Trivium core (grammar, logic, rhetoric) across grades, with Great Books / primary-sources integration and a history continuum. - Implement Socratic seminars and memory-work-based pedagogy in core subjects, with a Scholé rhythm. - Establish a “living curriculum” with teacher portraits and ongoing faculty development in classical methods. - Build a robust parent-formation program, including book clubs, lectures, and family liturgical alignment.

What Would Move the Needle

- Introduce a clearly defined Trivium-based curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric) with associated texts and a Great Books component; implement Latin/Greek options where feasible; embed a Western historical survey as a core element.
 - Institutionalize Socratic pedagogy (regular seminars, guided dialogue, Paideia-style seminars) in upper grades, with a rhetoric-focused capstone program.
 - Adopt and publicly publish a “living curriculum” framework—faculty as exemplars, mentors, and living stewards of classical formation.
 - Create a formal parent-education track (book clubs, lectures, family liturgy alignment) and open-campus opportunities that position parents as co-teachers and co-learners.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
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